all the rebels who had defected from the Mughals to the Uzbeks. Mirza Mirak Mashhadi, who had defected from the imperial camp, was tortured for five days by an elephant, who ‘twisted him in its trunk, stepped on him…and shook him from side to side’, until he was finally pardoned, possibly more dead than alive.

After the Uzbek rebellions were conclusively crushed, there would be a reappraisal of ancient ties and old ways of shaping the Mughal nobility. Earlier in the decade, Akbar had begun recruiting other Indian Muslims, the Sayyids of Baraha, migrants and brave warriors from Persia who had settled in Sirhind since the thirteenth century. Now Munim Khan himself would be transferred to the provincial capital of Jaunpur, effectively ending his career as a powerful wakil at the centre. A Chaghatai nobleman of the old guard, he had proved himself too intractable in his ways and too forgiving of disaffection when it originated from men from the old order. In the first twenty years of Akbar’s reign, the number of Persian noblemen of high rank would reflect this change of guard, and would swell to 38 per cent, almost at a par now with the Turanis at 39 per cent.

There was another family deemed too powerful at this time to remain in their concentrated jagirs in the Punjab—the Ataka Khail. Soon after the Uzbek rebellion, the members of the Ataka Khail were summoned to court and reassigned jagirs so that they were dispersed throughout the empire ‘like the constellation of the Bear in the sky’, as Akbar himself proudly claimed. Only Aziz Koka, Akbar’s beloved old playmate from his Kabul days, was allowed to retain his jagir. As for the Uzbek nobility, the clan was scattered and fragmented and would never again challenge Akbar’s supremacy. Akbar now also pragmatically restored Gondwana to its earlier ruling family, represented by a brother of Durgavati’s deceased husband, keeping only ten forts from Gondwana and making them a part of the subah of Malwa.

In the course of this year Akbar was petitioned by the ulema, the body of Islamic scholars appointed to the court, regarding the burial site of one Mir Murtaza Sharif Shirazi. The two main members of the ulema, Shaikh Abd un-Nabi and Abdullah Sultanpuri, were narrow-minded men and scholars whose religious learning was shallow and suspect but at the beginning of Akbar’s reign, their power was incontrovertible. Abd un-Nabi had been given wide-ranging powers and a great deal of resources to use at his discretion for ‘deserving people’ while Abdullah Sultanpuri’s fatwa